

you the hundreds of thousands of apps that populate the Play Store.

10. Use virtual buttons/swipe gestures for back/menu/home

If your phone has hardware buttons for home/menu and back, chances are these buttons might wear out over time and eventually stop functioning. Button Saviour, Virtual button Bar and Zsmooth Root are apps that allow you to use on-screen equivalents of your phone's hardware buttons and also add some intuitive swipe gestures for back/menu and home.

Why shouldn't I root my phone?

Like we've said before, rooting will almost certainly void your device's warranty, and any damage that might occur to your phone during or after the rooting process will not be covered under the warranty. This is purely a statutory warning though, most modern rooting methods are quite safe and cases of phones being 'bricked' while rooting are highly rare. Nevertheless, rooting is not for the faint at heart, and some root applications like SetCPU if misused, can wreck havoc on your phone's internals and cause irreparable damage to the device. There is, however, some consolation in the fact that one can usually reverse the process and un-root a device, making it almost impossible to detect if it had been rooted earlier.

Custom ROMs in Android

While rooting certainly extends your device's capabilities to a large extent, your device is capable of a lot more. Instead of simply accessorizing your phone, why not give it a completely new wardrobe? For Android geeks, flashing a new firmware onto their devices is the ultimate exercise in customizing one's Android experience. So just what is a custom ROM, why would one want to install (or 'flash') a new ROM onto his device and how does one go about the process? We're here to show you.

NOTE

You do NOT need to be rooted in order to sideload applications on your Android device. Just check the 'Install from Unknown Sources' option under Settings > Applications. Any application in the form of a valid .apk file can be installed on your device by copying the file into your phone's external storage, navigating to the file using a file manager and selecting the .apk file.